



2018 VOLVO XC40 TECHNOLOGY, FIRST DRIVE REVIEW: A CLASS ABOVE

The new Volvo XC40 makes a delayed entry into the popular entry-segment luxury market in India, but has a lot of elements that make it a very interesting package.

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BUILD, DESIGN AND AESTHETICS

The 2018 Volvo XC40 shows clear semblance to the XC60 and even the XC90. The overall design of the body provides an imposing stance. The nose is sharp and angular, and the wide wheel arches can accommodate 20-inch wheels. The XC40 gets a rear spoiler, stop lamps on the rear bumper, twin-chrome exhausts and a scuff plate.

Inside, the steering wheel has a familiar layout, and so does the overall dashboard design. There is a big, bright digital instrument cluster, and all the controls are minimalistically laid out. As with the bigger Volvos, you get Volvo's Sensus infotainment display with a 9-inch screen. Further down, you get a slot to stow away your smartphone, and this housing also has a Qi wireless charging pad. There are two USB slots with one that allows fast charging, and a cigarette lighter beside it.

The central column has no toggles (unlike its bigger siblings), and instead gets a bunch of cubbyholes to store stuff. The central armrest is not height-adjustable, but opens up a decent amount of space inside. Volvo has also included a

dustbin in the car with spring-loaded release. To the rear, you get decent storage areas on the doors. The central column gets no extra storage for the rear passengers, but includes a 12V power socket, dedicated AC vents and seat heating for rear passengers too.

The leather-bound seats can be controlled electronically to adjust lumbar support, recline, pitch and height. The rear seats are similarly bolstered, but are a bit too upright.

The boot has a 460-litre volume with all seats up.

THE TECHNOLOGY ARSENAL

The XC40 is the only car in this segment that includes ADAS systems. The entire tech arsenal includes a central camera and a rear-parking camera with parking sensors, electronic stability control with active torque distribution and permanent all-wheel drive, satellite-linked

road sign recognition, adaptive cruise control, and more. The Volvo Sensus infotainment system comes with Apple CarPlay, Android Auto and satellite-linked navigation system, a 13-speaker Harman/Kardon stereo audio system with 660W amplifier and subwoofer, with voice-based commands and controls. Other features include heated front and rear seats, wireless charging, cooled glove box and a digital instrument cluster to boot.

DRIVE AND RIDE QUALITY

The eight-speed gearbox is an absolute charm, and shifts smoothly and adjusts ratios brilliantly. You also get manual controls with the gear knob and paddle shifters, which allows you to hold revs and shoot out faster, but the default gearbox is fast enough and overtaking is never an issue.

Our tests recorded 0-100kph in 8.58 seconds, and when you leave it to the auto 'box alone in the flat-out Dynamic drive mode, it took 11.6 seconds to reach 100kph from standstill. It did feel a bit timid towards the end, but high speed braking fared really well, which induces further confidence in the car. 

- **Price:** TBA (est. ₹42-45 lac ex-showroom);
- **Powertrain:** Volvo D4 diesel, 190bhp/400Nm, Aisin 8-speed automatic, Haldex permanent AWD;
- **Fuel economy:** NA;
- **Pros:** Smart design, Good quality, Excellent technology package, Sublime audio system, Smooth engine, Good power delivery, Good highway ride quality, Pirelli P Zero tyres as standard;
- **Cons:** Stiff rear seat, Weak-ish low range;